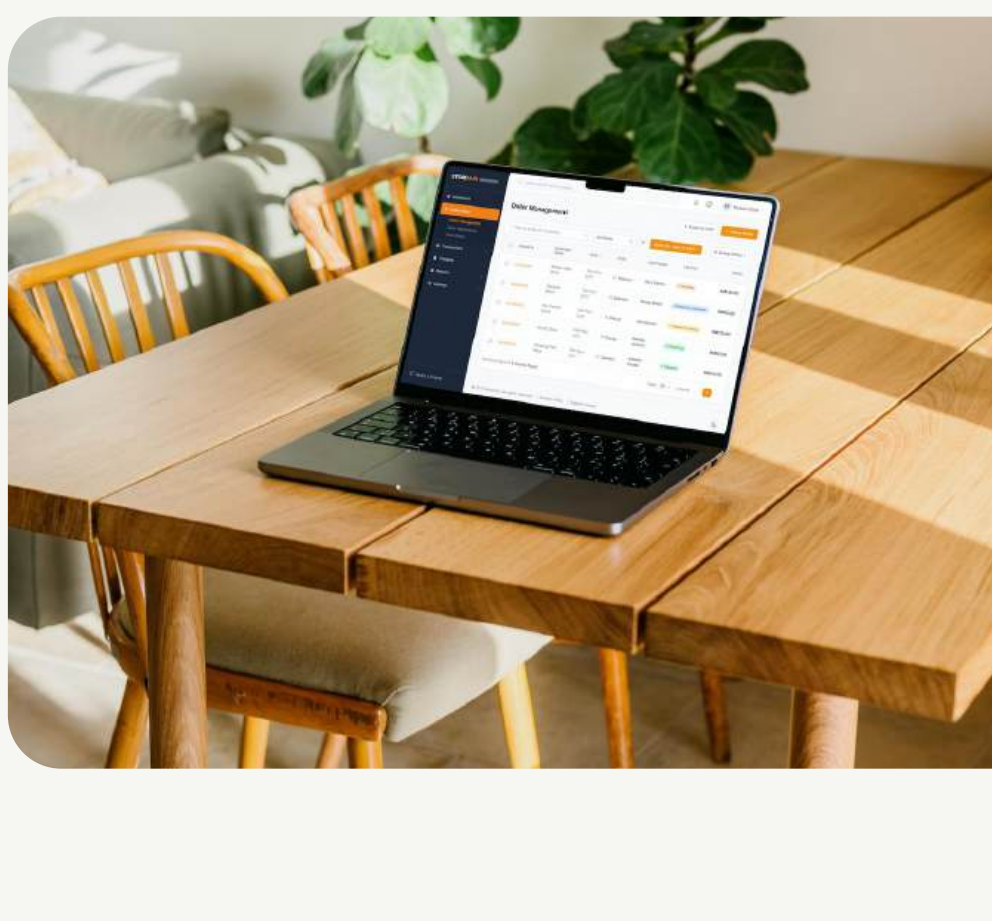


Taking SEA Retail Online From Zero

Designing the end-to-end marketplace experience that let thousands of **Southeast Asian store owners sell their inventory online** without starting over from scratch.



ROLE Product Designer	Markets Malaysia, Singapore	Platform Desktop + Tablet	Timeline 2017-2018
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1 Impact & Reflection

3K → 13K+

Merchant stores - Series A to 2021
Source: TechCrunch, The Edge Malaysia

+10-18k RM

Average increase in monthly transaction volume across the same period

48 hrs

Time to launch Beep Delivery during COVID-19, only possible because this online commerce architecture already existed

Catalog sync

Most cited reason merchants completed setup in post-launch surveys validating the core design hypothesis

The Business Problem 2

50-80%

SEA retailers had no digital commerce presence at project start

3,000+

Active StoreHub merchants with digitised inventory - none selling online

4

Markets to design for: Malaysia, Thailand, Singapore, Philippines

A massive market stuck offline

The infrastructure existed. The barrier was perception, confidence, and friction. **Going online looked and felt like starting a completely new business.**

The design challenge: **make it feel like a switch, not a transformation.**

INSIGHT 01

Catalog anxiety was barrier #1

Merchants with 100+ SKUs felt that going online meant re-entering everything. The mental model of "upload your products" triggered dread before they even started.

INSIGHT 02

Identity gap as real as UX gap

Even tech-savvy owners didn't see themselves as online sellers. An online store felt like a different business. The framing problem was as critical as the interface problem.

INSIGHT 03

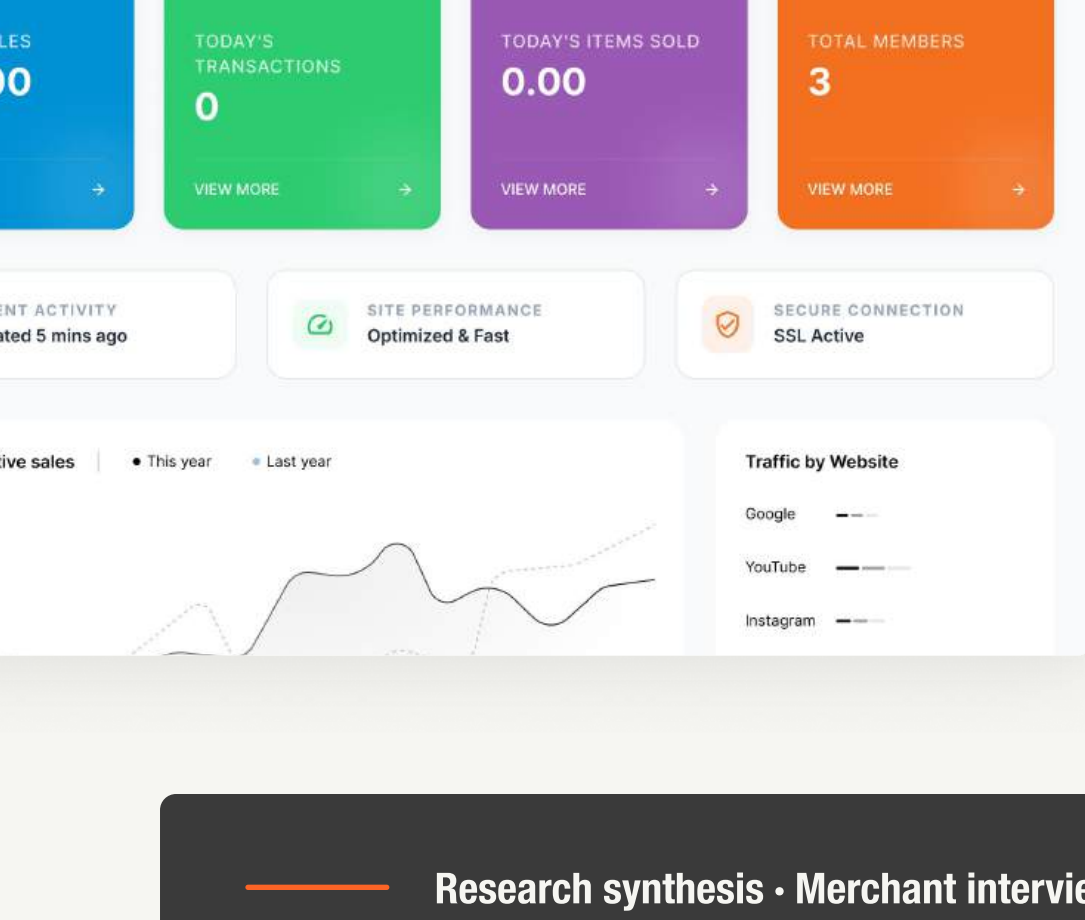
Platform trust doesn't auto-transfer

Merchants trusted StoreHub deeply from years of in-store use. That trust didn't automatically extend to a new surface. Familiarity had to be carried forward deliberately.

INSIGHT 04

Regional nuance, shared core anxiety

Thai merchants favoured conversational selling via Line. Filipino merchants were deeply mobile-first. But across all four markets: the same fear of complexity, effort, and loss of control.



ORDER ID	SHIPPING FROM	DATE	TYPE	CUSTOMER
SHUB1001	Kelana Jaya Store	15th Nov 2017	Delivery	Vera Barton
SHUB1002	Bangsar Store	15th Nov 2017	Delivery	Rhoda Watts
SHUB1003	NU Central Store	15th Nov 2017	Pickup	Vera Barton
SHUB1004	KLCC Store	15th Nov 2017	Pickup	Wesley Jenkins
SHUB1005	Ampang Park Store	15th Nov 2017	Delivery	Isabelle Frazier

Research synthesis • Merchant interviews, MY & PH cohorts • 2017

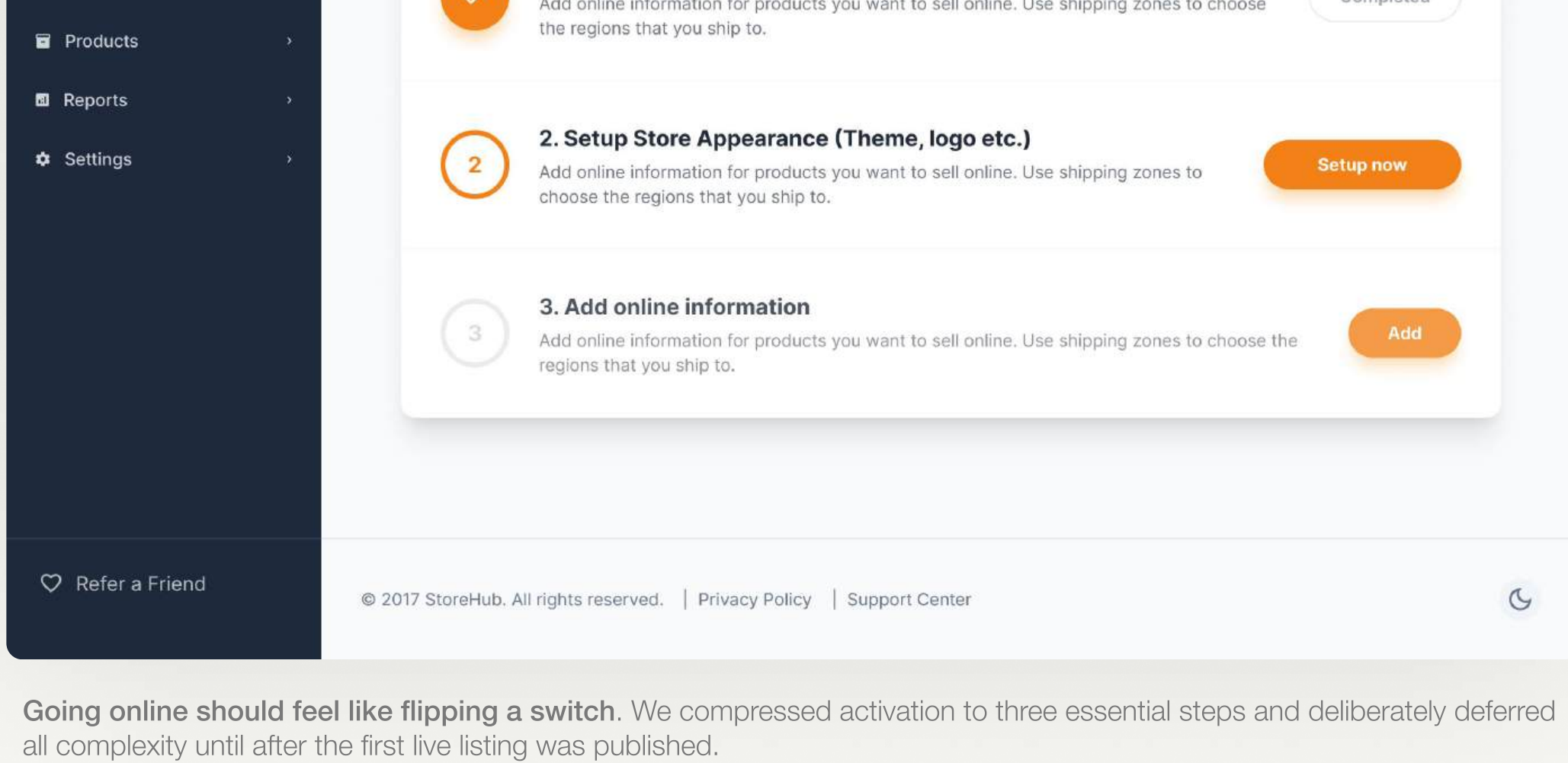
"Going online sounded like starting over. They saw Lazada, Shopee and felt they'd be competing with thousands of sellers, constantly repricing, losing their customer relationship. Our framing had to be fundamentally different."

3 Design Strategy & Key Moves

Three principles before any screen

01

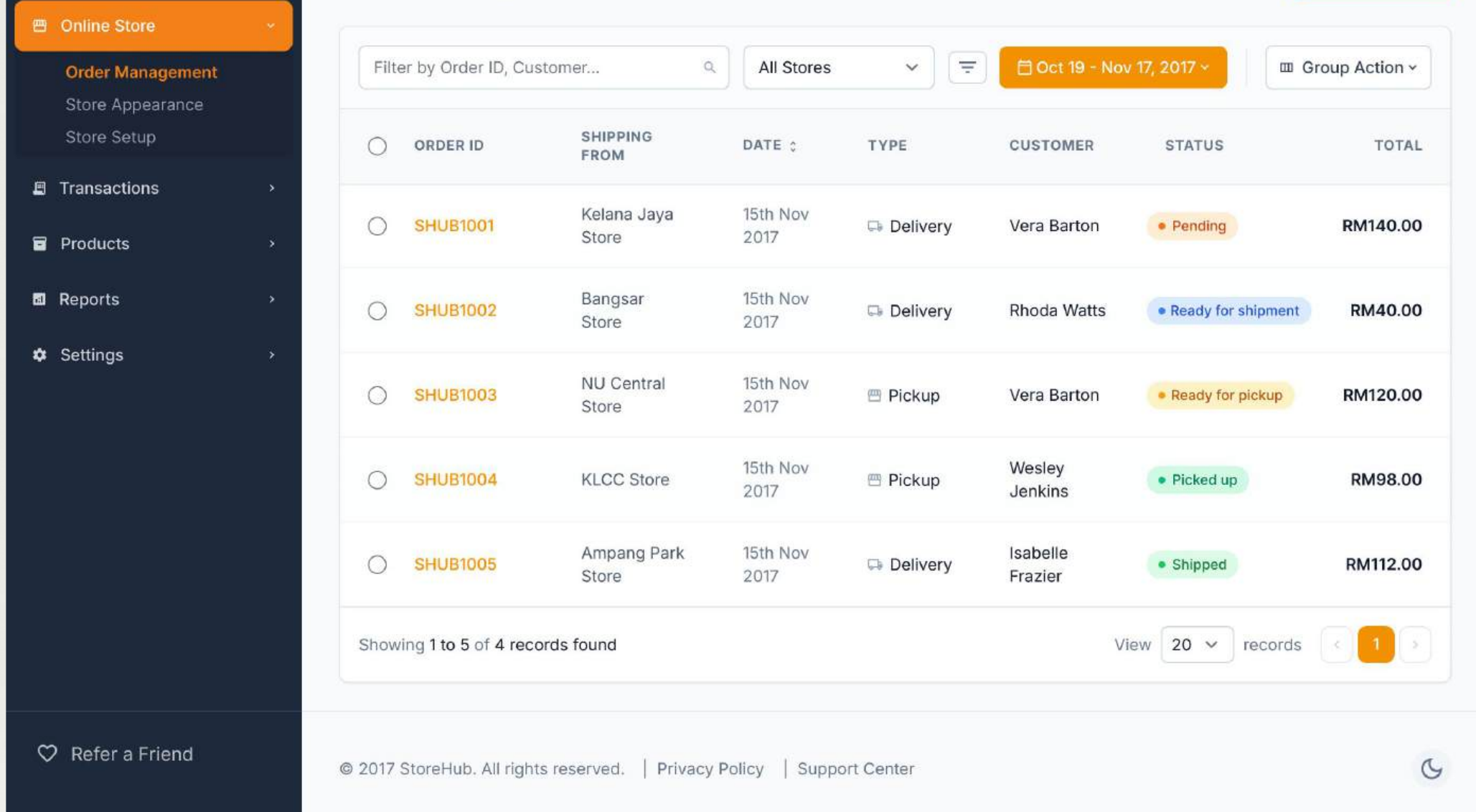
Shrink the leap, not the ambition



Going online should feel like flipping a switch. We compressed activation to three essential steps and deliberately deferred all complexity until after the first live listing was published.

02

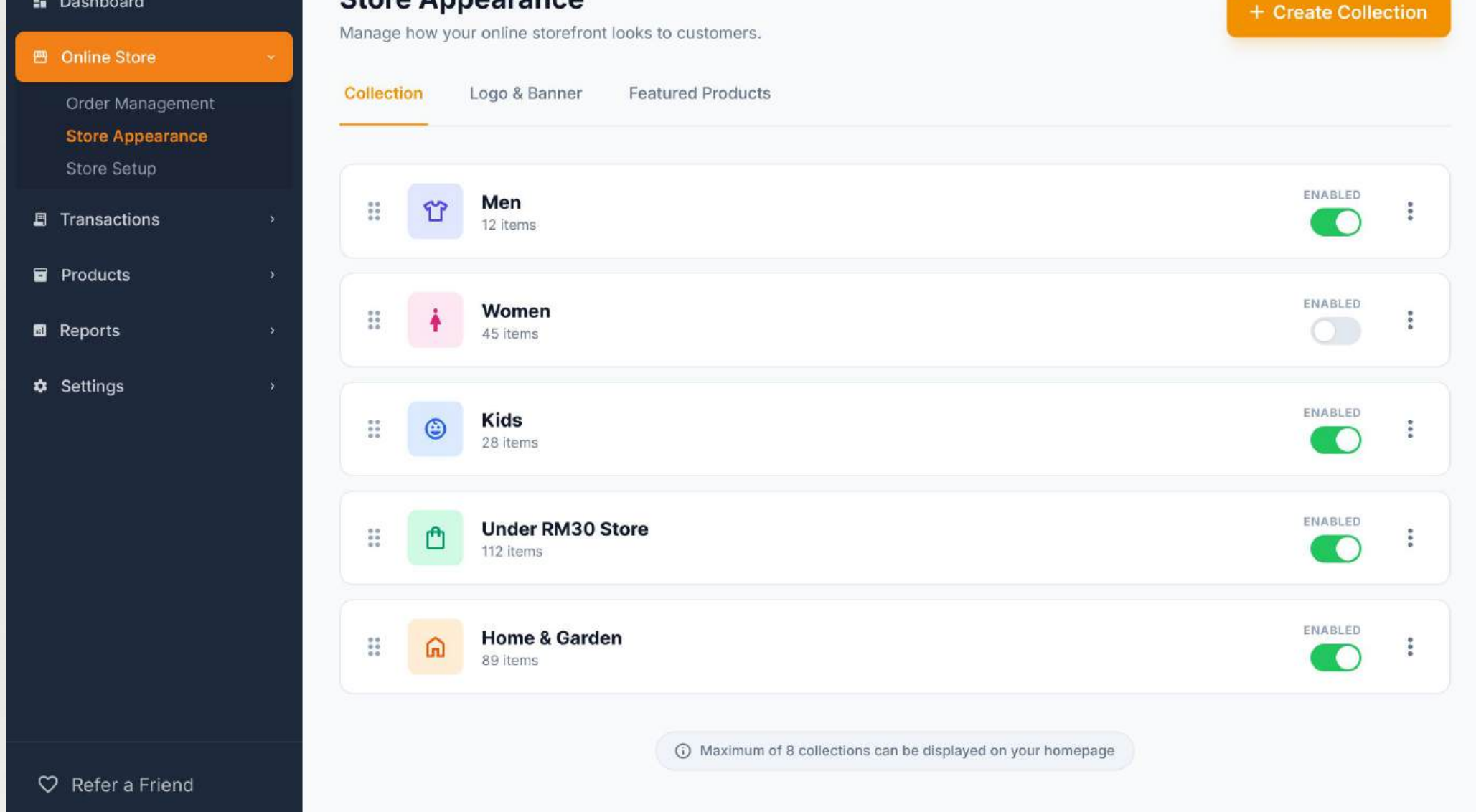
Leverage what already exists



Merchants had already built their catalog in StoreHub. Every design decision started with: **how do we make what they've built usable, not replaceable?** Catalog sync wasn't a feature it was the foundation.

03

Design for Malaysia first, flex for the region



Rather than diluting the experience for a generic SEA audience, **we built deeply for Malaysian merchants** their language, categories, and norms then built structural flexibility for TH and PH.

Four pivotal design decisions 4

Critical activation moment

Catalog Sync — Turn POS Inventory Into Online Listings

We pulled product data, SKUs, categories, and pricing directly from existing StoreHub inventory. The merchant's job was to review and publish, not rebuild.

North star metric

Onboarding Flow: Make the First Hour Count

Activation: publishing at least one live product was the metric we designed toward. Setup stripped to three steps: connect identity, sync catalog, go live.

Identity & ownership

Storefront Builder — Give Merchants a Space That's Theirs

A clean shareable URL that felt like theirs, not StoreHub's. Ownership over the storefront was the emotional unlock for activation.

Operational continuity

Order Management — Close the Loop Back to POS

Online orders appeared within the familiar StoreHub dashboard not a separate inbox or external tool.

Personal reflection • StoreHub Marketplace, 2017-2018

"The marketplace wasn't just a feature, it was the move that changed what StoreHub was. Designing it from zero meant every decision we made became the foundation everything else was built on."

Thanks you!

check out more work at: darbara.github.io/portfolio